

CORPORATE CRACKDOWN

With Vijay Mallya's washing his IPL team's dirty linen in public, India's cricketers discover the other side of cash-rich franchises

■ By Sharda Ugra

Trump the compulsive showman to trump it all: Shah Rukh Khan's Pied Piper act, Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje Scindia's custom-made *leheriya* sari with Jaipur's IPL colours and Preity Zinta's wide-eyed enthusiasm. With a spectacular display of toy-flinging petulance, Vijay Mallya, beer baron, airline magnate, tycoon-at-large, F-1 team owner, managed to turn the spotlight onto himself.

As his Rs 445-crore Bangalore Royal Challengers Indian Premier League (IPL) team hit the rock bottom, Mallya sacked his CEO Charu Sharma and then distanced himself from the team selection, dishing out low blows to captain Rahul Dravid in the bargain. The Challengers have lost seven matches out of nine and have little to play for now other than Mallya's ire and the increasing amusement of his sniggering social set.

For Indian cricket, this has been an illuminating episode. After all, even before the IPL, the corporate world was its most snugly bedfellow. Mallya's swift abandonment of his struggling team has shown just how far big business' attachment to cricket goes—only until the next victory, exactly like the fickle, effigy-burning fan. Except that this fan wields a fat cheque book that few inside Indian cricket have been able to resist.

The Challengers and their sore-loser boss may be at the extreme end of this phenomenon, but IPL's cricketers have all felt the heavy breath of corporate impatience after a few defeats. In his newspaper column, M.S. Dhoni noted how supportive his management at the Chennai Super Kings was. Even

so, after Kings lost three in a row, sources say the team received a firm speech to remind them of just what the stakes were and how there were investors to answer to. As the Delhi Daredevils slid down the points table, its directors looked through the team personnel they had engulfed in bear hugs after victory. "A message has been sent out to the team, you can sense the nervous edge," said a Delhi Daredevils squad member.

With every reverse, franchises see their operational expenses of anything between Rs 30-50-crore this season going down the tube, taking their brand value with it. To them, leaning on players is like cracking down on underperforming departments.

Mallya's sacking of CEO Sharma certainly cranked up the anxiety levels. As Bangalore lost, Sharma had become the buffer between the increasingly bad-tempered "Company" and the players. With Mallya turning the heat on his subordinates, executives began to sit in on Challengers team meetings, once reportedly button-holing the team data analyst to crunch numbers for them.

Challengers' Chief Cricketing Officer Martin Crowe then presented the executives' statistical theories to flummoxed players. The next day, the batting collapsed and the team lost again. A Challengers insider says, "Corporate guys think if you practice four hours instead of having the normal two-hour net, you will play twice as well." Coach Venkatesh Prasad only narrowly saved his job when Dravid hinted he too would walk out if Prasad was removed.

Not everyone's public facade has cracked as openly as Mallya's but in pri-



"I had a separate list"

vate the franchise business has shown up its less attractive face.

One boss demanded an explanation from a cricketer as to why their team was dropping catches. When a captain tried to assuage an angry management man by saying that the players were trying their damndest, he had his head bitten off. The cricketers are not amused. An India player says, "The franchises are being obnoxious. We wouldn't dream of telling them how to run their businesses. The last thing you need is them telling you how to play cricket."

The freemarket cheerleaders claim that corporate accountability is IPL's biggest gift to Indian cricket. It could have been had those making calls on cricketers been experts or master practitioners of the sport they now own. A Mumbai Indians senior executive sat up